✝️ Christian Humanism Study Guide

Procadamia — 2nd Trimester Review | Chapters 1–6

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Chapter 1 — Foundations of Ethics

4 Key Terms

Core Concepts

- **End / Intention** — The purpose or goal toward which an action is directed. Every human act has an end — the reason *why* we act. The end gives meaning and moral direction to what we do.
- **Means** — The actions or methods used to achieve a particular end. The moral quality of the means matters independently of the end — *"the end does not justify the means."*
- **First Principle** — The foundational moral truth: **"Do good and avoid evil."** Known through synderesis (the innate moral sense); the starting point of all moral reasoning.
- **Ethics** — The branch of philosophy that studies human actions in terms of their moral goodness or badness. Asks: "What should I do?" and "What makes an action right or wrong?"

Key Relationships

Concept	Definition	Key Point
End	Goal / purpose of an action	The "why" — gives moral direction
Means	Methods used to reach the end	The "how" — must also be morally good
First Principle	"Do good and avoid evil"	Self-evident; known through synderesis

Ethics	Study of moral goodness/badness of acts	Practical — about what we SHOULD do

⚠️ **Exam Trap:** A good end does NOT justify immoral means. Both must be evaluated separately.

Chapter 2 — Happiness

10 Key Terms

Core Concepts

- **Happiness** — Complete fulfillment from achieving one's ultimate end. NOT mere pleasure — it is the fulfillment of human nature.
- **Human Nature** — Rational, social, free, and oriented toward the good. Understanding human nature is essential to understanding true happiness.
- **Good** — That which fulfills or perfects a being according to its nature.
- **Goods of the Body** — Health, strength, physical pleasure, life. Real goods, but *lower* in the hierarchy.
- **Goods of the Soul** — Wisdom, virtue, love, friendship, knowledge of truth. *Higher* goods — they perfect our rational nature.
- **Hierarchy of Goods** — Soul goods rank above body goods. The highest good is the Beatific Vision (union with God).
- **Ultimate End** — The final goal that, once achieved, leaves nothing more to be desired. In Christian Humanism: **God / the Beatific Vision**.
- **Substitutes for Happiness** — Wealth, pleasure, power, fame, honor. These are finite goods that cannot satisfy our infinite desire.
- **Beatific Vision** — Direct encounter with God in heaven — the only source of perfect, lasting happiness because only God is infinite.
- **Nature** — The essence of a thing — what makes it what it is.

Hierarchy of Goods (Lowest → Highest)

Level	Type	Examples	Why Limited
1 (lowest)	Substitutes	Wealth, fame, pleasure, power	Finite; cannot satisfy infinite desire
2	Goods of the Body	Health, strength, life	Physical — serve the soul's goods
3	Goods of the Soul	Wisdom, virtue, love, truth	High, but still created goods
4 (highest)	Beatific Vision	Union with God	Infinite — perfectly fulfills us

> 💡 Only the **infinite** (God) can satisfy an **infinite** desire. Finite goods always leave us wanting more.

⚠️ **Exam Trap:** Happiness ≠ Pleasure. Pleasure is temporary feeling; happiness is lasting fulfillment of nature.

Chapter 3 — Law

18 Key Terms

Definition of Law

A valid law requires all four elements:

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Law = Ordinance of Reason + For the Common Good + By Legitimate Authority +
Promulgated
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Types of Law (Hierarchy)

Type	Source	Known Through	Key Feature
Eternal Law	God's plan for all creation	Faith / Reason (partially)	Universal, unchanging
Natural Law	Human reason participating in Eternal Law	Reason alone	Written on the heart; 1st precept: "Do good, avoid evil"
Divine Law	God's revealed law (Scripture)	Revelation	Ten Commandments; supplements Natural Law
Human/Civil Law	Human lawmakers	Legislation	Must not contradict Natural or Divine Law

Rights and Duties

- **Right** — A moral claim one person has on another. Every right implies a corresponding duty.
- **Duty** — A moral obligation to respect others' rights. Rights and duties are correlative.
- **Subject of a Right** — The person who possesses the right (rights-holder).
- **Term of a Right** — The person who has the duty corresponding to that right (duty-bearer).
- **Matter of a Right** — The specific thing the right concerns (life, property, speech, etc.).

Freedom

Type	Definition	Moral Status

Genuine Freedom	The ability to choose the good	True freedom — ordered toward truth and goodness
Absolute Freedom	Doing anything without restriction	False — a distortion of true freedom

⚠️ **Exam Trap:** Natural Law vs. Divine Law — Natural Law is known through REASON; Divine Law requires REVELATION (Scripture).

⚠️ **Exam Trap:** Absolute Freedom ≠ Genuine Freedom. Absolute = do anything (false); Genuine = choose the good (true).

Chapter 4 — Conscience

15 Key Terms

What Conscience Is (and Isn't)

Conscience	Consciousness
A **judgment of the practical intellect** about the moral goodness/badness of a specific action	**Awareness** of one's own existence and surroundings
Rational — NOT a feeling	NOT a moral judgment

⚠️ **#1 Exam Trap:** Conscience ≠ Consciousness. These are completely different things.

Two Types of Intellect

Practical Intellect	Speculative Intellect
Directed toward **action** — what to DO	Directed toward **knowing truth** for its own sake — what IS
Conscience operates here	Abstract knowledge lives here

Moral Reasoning (Syllogism)

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Major Premise: "Stealing is wrong." (general principle) Minor Premise: "Taking this wallet is stealing." (specific case) Conclusion: "Taking this wallet is wrong." (judgment of conscience)
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Types of Conscience / Ignorance

Type	Definition	Moral Guilt?
Invincible Ignorance	Cannot be overcome even with reasonable effort	❌ NO — person genuinely could not have known
Vincible Ignorance	CAN be overcome but hasn't been	✅ YES — person should have known better
Erroneous Conscience	Makes a wrong moral judgment	Depends on invincible vs. vincible

Doubtful Conscience	Cannot reach a firm judgment	Must NOT act until doubt resolved

Synderesis

Synderesis — The innate, natural disposition to know first moral principles ("Do good and avoid evil"). It is:

- **Innate** — present from birth, not learned
- **Indestructible** — cannot be lost or removed
- The foundation of all moral reasoning

🔑 **Rule:** Never act with a doubtful conscience — resolve the doubt first through prayer, study, or counsel.

Chapter 5 — Human Acts

15 Key Terms

Human Acts vs. Acts of Man

Human Act	Act of Man
Performed WITH knowledge and free will	Performed WITHOUT knowledge and/or free will
CAN be morally evaluated (good or bad)	Cannot be morally evaluated
Examples: choosing to help, stealing, praying	Examples: breathing, digesting, reflex actions

⚠️ **Exam Trap:** Human Act ≠ Act of Man. Only human acts (deliberate choices) are subject to moral evaluation.

Components of a Human Act

- **Knowledge** — Awareness of what you're doing
- **Free Will** — The ability to choose otherwise
- **Deliberation** — Considering options before choosing
- **Intention** — The purpose or goal in mind
- **Consent** — The will accepting a course of action

Interior vs. Exterior Acts

Interior Act	Exterior Act
Occurs within the mind/will (thoughts, intentions)	Physical, observable action in the world
Has moral value even if never expressed externally	The visible expression of interior acts

Passion and Moral Responsibility

Type	Timing	Effect on Guilt
Antecedent Passion	Arises BEFORE a decision	⬇️ **Diminishes** responsibility — clouded judgment
Consequent Passion	Arises AFTER a decision (willed by you)	➡️ **Does NOT diminish** — may even increase

> ⚠️ **Exam Trap:** Antecedent passion REDUCES guilt (emotion came first). Consequent passion does NOT (you chose to fuel it).

What Diminishes Voluntariness

1. **Ignorance** — Invincible ignorance removes guilt; vincible does not
2. **Passion** — Antecedent diminishes; consequent does not
3. **Habit** — Can make acts less conscious, but you're still responsible for forming the habit

Chapter 6 — Morality of Human Acts

20 Key Terms

The Three Sources of Morality

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For an act to be MORALLY GOOD: Object ✓ + End/Intention ✓ + Circumstances ✓ (ALL three must be good)
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Source	What It Is	Key Rule
Object	WHAT is being done (the core action)	Primary determinant — some objects are intrinsically evil
End / Intention	WHY the person is doing it	Good end ≠ justify evil means
Circumstances	Context: who, what, where, when, how much	Can modify gravity but CANNOT make intrinsically evil acts good

⚠️ **Intrinsically Evil Acts** (murder, lying, adultery, etc.) are ALWAYS wrong — no intention or circumstance can justify them.

Proximate vs. Remote End

Proximate End	Remote End
The immediate, closest "why"	The further, bigger picture "why" behind the proximate end

Physical Evil vs. Moral Evil

Physical Evil	Moral Evil
Natural suffering: disease, disasters	Evil from free human choice against moral law
NOT caused by human moral choices	Sin is moral evil

Principle of Double Effect

When an action has BOTH good and bad effects, ALL FOUR conditions must be met:

1. The **act itself** must be morally good or neutral (not intrinsically evil)
2. The **good effect** must be intended; the bad effect only tolerated (not desired)

3. The good effect must **NOT come through the bad effect** (bad effect is not the means)
4. There must be **proportionate reason** — the good must outweigh the bad

💡 Classic example: A surgeon removes a cancerous organ, knowing the patient will lose that function. The bad (loss of organ) is tolerated, not intended, and the good (saving life) proportionately outweighs it.

Types of Cooperation with Evil

Type	Definition	Always Wrong?
Formal	Share in the evil **intention** — you approve and intend the wrongdoing	✅ YES — always wrong
Material	Contribute to evil act WITHOUT sharing evil intention	❌ May be permissible (evaluate with Double Effect)
Immediate	Directly participate in the evil act itself	Usually wrong; very hard to justify
Mediate	Contribute to circumstances that make evil possible	Easier to justify than immediate
Proximate	Closely connected to the evil act	Harder to justify
Remote	Distantly connected to the evil act	Easier to justify
Active	Doing something that contributes to another's evil	Depends on type
Passive	Failing to prevent another's evil when you could	Sinful if you have a duty to act

⚠️ **Exam Trap:** Formal cooperation = share the evil INTENT (always wrong). Material cooperation = contribute without sharing intent (may be OK).

⚠️ **Exam Trap:** Sins of *omission* are real sins. Failing to act when you should is morally culpable.

⭐ Master Summary — All Key Terms

Term	Chapter	Brief Definition
Ethics	1	Study of moral goodness/badness of human actions
First Principle	1	"Do good and avoid evil" — foundation of all morality
End / Intention	1, 6	The WHY — purpose or goal of an action
Means	1	The HOW — methods used to reach the end
Happiness	2	Complete fulfillment from achieving one's ultimate end
Ultimate End	2	God / Beatific Vision — final goal that leaves nothing more to desire
Goods of the Soul	2	Wisdom, virtue, love, truth — higher than goods of the body
Substitutes for Happiness	2	Wealth, pleasure, power, fame — finite; cannot truly satisfy
Beatific Vision	2	Direct encounter with God in heaven — perfect happiness
Law	3	Ordinance of reason, for common good, by authority, promulgated
Eternal Law	3	God's plan for all creation — universal and unchanging
Natural Law	3	Human reason's participation in Eternal Law — known through reason
Divine Law	3	God's revealed law (Scripture) — supplements Natural Law
Promulgate	3	To make a law officially known to those it binds
Genuine Freedom	3	Ability to choose the good — true freedom
Right / Duty	3	Moral claim / corresponding obligation — always paired
Conscience	4	Judgment of practical intellect about moral goodness/badness
Synderesis	4	Innate moral sense — indestructible; knows "do good/avoid evil"
Invincible Ignorance	4, 5	Cannot be overcome — removes moral guilt
Vincible Ignorance	4, 5	Can be overcome but wasn't — moral guilt remains

Doubtful Conscience	4	Cannot reach firm judgment — must NOT act until resolved
Human Act	5	Deliberate act with knowledge and free will — morally evaluable
Act of Man	5	Involuntary action (breathing, reflex) — NOT morally evaluable
Antecedent Passion	5	Emotion BEFORE decision — diminishes moral responsibility
Consequent Passion	5	Emotion AFTER decision — does NOT diminish responsibility
Object of the Act	6	WHAT is being done — primary source of morality
Intrinsically Evil Act	6	ALWAYS wrong — no intention/circumstance can justify it
Three Sources of Morality	6	Object + End/Intention + Circumstances (all must be good)
Double Effect	6	4-condition framework for acts with both good and bad effects
Formal Cooperation	6	Share evil intention — ALWAYS wrong
Material Cooperation	6	Contribute without evil intention — may be permissible
Sins of Omission	6	Failing to do what one ought to — real moral failures

📖 **Study Tip:** The four most common exam traps are: (1) Conscience ≠ Consciousness, (2) Human Act ≠ Act of Man, (3) Antecedent vs. Consequent Passion, and (4) Formal vs. Material Cooperation.